VUGA NDAKUMVA

GENDER-BASED VIOLENCE EDUCATIONAL CONTENT LIBRARY

CHAPTER 02

Types and Forms of Gender-Based Violence

A detailed, survivor-centred educational chapter with definitions, warning signs, practical scenarios, learning activities, and sources.

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Chapter learning objectives

After working through this chapter, a reader should be able to identify several forms of gender-based violence (GBV), explain why harmful acts can overlap, recognize patterns of control without diagnosing a situation from a checklist, understand barriers to disclosure, and identify safer routes to information, health care and specialist support.

A note to readers: This chapter discusses violence, including non-graphic references to sexual abuse and threats. You may skip any section. You are not required to remember or disclose personal experiences, complete activities, confront anyone, or prove that harm has occurred. Read only when and where it feels safe.

1. Understanding what counts as GBV

Gender-based violence refers to harmful actions directed against people because of gender or unequal gender-related power relations. It can occur in private and public, in person and through technology. It includes physical, sexual, psychological and economic harm, threats, coercion, and deprivation of liberty. Women and girls experience GBV disproportionately, while people of any gender may be affected. [1-3]

The word **form** describes how abuse is carried out - for example, a threat, an unwanted sexual act, or withholding money as a means of control. The word **setting** describes where or in which relationship it occurs - for example, within a partnership, at school, in a workplace, or online. A single incident can involve multiple forms in more than one setting.

Not every disagreement or financial difficulty is violence. To understand a concerning situation, consider whether there is coercion, intimidation, non-consent, a pattern of domination, threats or intentional harm, and the wider context. A survivor should not be expected to collect evidence or label their experience before they deserve respectful support.

2. Physical violence

Physical violence includes using physical force to injure, hurt, frighten, restrain, or control another person. It may include pushing, hitting, kicking, burning, restraining someone against their will, or preventing access to necessary medical care. Physical violence is serious even when it leaves no visible mark. [2,4]

Common warning signs and misunderstandings

- A person describes being grabbed, restrained, threatened with a weapon, or physically punished for disobedience.
- Someone is prevented from leaving a place, obtaining urgent care, or seeking help after an injury.
- A partner or family member minimizes an assault as “discipline,” “love,” or a one-time mistake.

Visible injuries are not required for someone to experience harm. Conversely, an injury alone does not establish who caused it; professional assessment should be sensitive to context and safety. Assault involving strangulation or pressure to the neck may cause serious injury even without obvious marks and needs urgent medical assessment.

Case A - An argument at home

Scenario: During a disagreement, a partner pushes another person against a wall, blocks the door and warns them not to speak to relatives.

How to understand it: The pushing and restriction of movement are physical acts; the warning and isolation are also psychological or controlling behaviors.

Safer response: A supporter should first consider immediate safety, avoid confronting the person using violence, and offer access to trusted professional support.

3. Sexual violence and sexual coercion

Sexual violence involves sexual acts, attempted acts or unwanted sexual contact or attention imposed without free agreement, including by force, threats, manipulation, or misuse of authority. It may be committed by a stranger, acquaintance, spouse, partner, teacher, supervisor or other person. Being in a marriage or relationship does not create permanent consent. [1,3,7]

Consent must be freely given, informed, specific and revocable. Silence, fear, freezing, previous agreement, intoxication, or dependence on another person do not establish freely given consent. The legal treatment of specific acts and ages varies by jurisdiction; trained local practitioners must interpret relevant laws.

Sexual harassment, exploitation, and abuse

Sexual harassment can involve unwelcome sexual comments, pressure, messages, advances or touching. Sexual exploitation involves abusing a position of vulnerability, trust or authority for sexual purposes. Examples include demanding sexual favors in exchange for a job opportunity or essential assistance. Children need child-protection responses, and adults should never ask children to describe abuse in detail outside a trained safeguarding process.

Case B - A job opportunity

Scenario: A supervisor implies that a trainee will lose a placement unless they agree to unwanted sexual contact.

How to understand it: This involves pressure backed by an unequal power relationship, potentially sexual harassment, coercion and exploitation.

Safer response: The trainee should not be required to confront the supervisor or file a complaint before being offered confidential information on independent reporting and support options.

Time-sensitive health consideration: Following sexual assault, seek medical attention as soon as safely possible. Clinicians can assess injuries, sexually transmitted infection risks, pregnancy prevention and other needs. HIV post-exposure prophylaxis (PEP), when indicated, should start as soon as possible and no later than 72 hours after possible exposure; other care remains valuable even after that window. [7,8]

4. Psychological and emotional violence

Psychological abuse involves actions that intimidate, degrade, manipulate, isolate, threaten or undermine a person. Emotional abuse is commonly used to describe repeated humiliation, belittling, threats, guilt-based control, or attacks on self-worth. These terms overlap; one incident or pattern may cause harm even without physical violence. [2,3,4]

Examples include threats of harm, repeated insults, forcing isolation from family, using children to threaten a caregiver, or deliberately creating fear. “Gaslighting” is a non-clinical popular term often used for attempts to cause someone to doubt their perceptions; it should not replace clear descriptions of actual conduct.

It is important not to diagnose an entire relationship from a single insensitive comment. Look instead at coercion, power, repeated behavior, the ability to disagree safely, and impact on autonomy. No one needs a formal label to ask for support.

Case C - Messages and isolation

Scenario: A student is told by their partner that all friendships are disloyal. The partner repeatedly insults the student, monitors every conversation, and threatens to spread rumors.

How to understand it: Repeated intimidation, humiliation and forced isolation may amount to psychological abuse and coercive control.

Safer response: Avoid urging a public confrontation. Ask whether it is safe to communicate, whether devices are monitored, and what support the student would prefer.

5. Economic and financial abuse

Economic abuse uses money, access to work, education, property or essential resources to limit a person's independence or control their decisions. It can include confiscating earnings, denying access to basic necessities as punishment, sabotaging employment, coercing debt, or preventing someone from attending school. [2,3]

Economic abuse is not identical to poverty or a jointly agreed household budget. The distinguishing concern is coercive restriction, exploitation or deprivation rather than limited income alone. A person may be unable to leave an unsafe relationship because of dependent children, lack of transport, housing insecurity or fear of losing school fees.

Case D - A family business

Scenario: A married person works daily in a family shop, but their partner confiscates all earnings, forbids paid employment elsewhere and withholds transport money as punishment for visiting friends.

How to understand it: This may involve economic control combined with isolation.

Safer response: A supporter can discuss safe and discreet access to services, documents, income-related advice and practical help without insisting that the person leave immediately.

6. Technology-facilitated GBV

Technology-facilitated abuse uses phones, social media, messaging platforms, location-sharing services or other digital tools to threaten, track, shame, exploit or control a person. Offline and online forms often overlap. Some acts include repeated threatening messages, unauthorized access to accounts, tracking location without consent, publication of private information, and sharing intimate images without permission. [2,5]

A person experiencing technology-facilitated abuse may fear that changing passwords, deleting an app or blocking someone could escalate danger. Safety decisions should consider whether the other person has device access or controls accounts. Digital safety guidance should be personalized by a trained practitioner when risk is high.

Case E - Online threats

Scenario: A former partner threatens to publish private photographs unless a person resumes contact and shares their current location.

How to understand it: Threats, image-based abuse and coercive control may be present even when no physical contact occurs.

Safer response: Do not forward images or encourage public retaliation. Seek safe specialist support, consider reporting platform abuse when appropriate, and preserve information only if it is safe and lawful to do so.

7. Social, reproductive and identity-related coercion

Some violence occurs through controlling social participation, mobility, marriage choices or reproductive decisions. Examples include forced marriage, threats for refusing a relationship, interference with access to reproductive healthcare, or restricting movement for gender-based reasons. Forms of reproductive coercion may include pressure concerning pregnancy or contraception. [3,9]

People may also be targeted because they do not conform to gender expectations. Faith, family and cultural background can be important sources of resilience, but no cultural or religious justification excuses violence or forced participation. Local law, child protection rules and clinical practice must be checked before providing legal or medical instructions.

8. GBV in different settings

Setting	Examples of potential GBV	Important consideration
Intimate relationships	Physical assault; sexual coercion; controlling behavior	A former partner may also pose risks
Family or household	Violence linked to gender roles; restrictions on autonomy	Not all family conflict is GBV
School or university	Sexual pressure linked to grades; harassment; stalking	Safeguarding and independent reporting matter
Workplace	Sexual harassment; retaliation after refusal	Employment power differences can increase vulnerability
Community/public spaces	Threats; harassment; targeted assaults	Access to safe transport and support matters
Digital spaces	Threats; non-consensual images; surveillance	The abuser may monitor the same device

9. How forms of GBV overlap

Forms of violence should not be treated as separate boxes. One individual may experience control of their finances, humiliation, threats of sexual harm and digital monitoring simultaneously. Understanding these connections helps avoid the mistaken belief that only physical injury makes an experience serious. The European Institute for Gender Equality describes a continuum of violence in which forms can reinforce one another. [6]

For example, a controlling partner may make a person financially dependent, demand constant location sharing, threaten family members and then use physical force when challenged. The overlapping pattern can create

barriers to seeking help. No reader should be encouraged to test whether another person will become violent.

10. Recognizing risk without creating a checklist diagnosis

Warning signs include threats, escalating intimidation, forced isolation, monitoring, stalking, coercive sexual demands, unwanted physical restraint, and deliberate restriction of necessities. These signs help people notice possible danger but cannot predict an individual's future actions reliably. Safety is a practical priority even when a situation does not fit a textbook pattern.

If someone is in immediate danger, the safest response may be to move toward a safer place and contact available emergency or specialist services, if doing so will not increase risk. Avoid telling a person to challenge an abuser, secretly record conversations or leave in a particular way; those decisions require context-sensitive planning.

11. Effects on survivors and why reactions differ

Possible consequences include injuries, fear, shame, distress, traumatic stress reactions, difficulty concentrating, disrupted education or work, reduced trust, financial loss and social isolation. Responses vary: some people disclose promptly, some remain silent, and others may show no obvious emotional reaction. None of these responses establishes whether harm occurred. [1,7]

A person may remain in contact with someone who has harmed them because of threats, affection, children, finances, disability-related needs, lack of trusted services or other circumstances. Support should focus on informed choices and safety, not judging the survivor's behavior.

12. Survivor-centred first-line support

WHO describes a structured approach known as **LIVES**: Listen, Inquire about needs and concerns, Validate, Enhance safety, and Support. This is a framework for trained providers; everyday supporters can adopt its respectful principles without undertaking an investigation or counselling role. [10]

Principle	What supportive behavior can sound like
Listen	"You can share only what you want to share."
Inquire	"What would be most useful or safest for you right now?"
Validate	"What happened is not something you deserved."
Enhance safety	"Would it help to discuss a safe person or place with a trained worker?"
Support	"I can help you find available services if you want."

Do not demand a detailed story, promise total secrecy, blame the survivor, press for forgiveness or reconciliation, or contact a suspected perpetrator without a safe and lawful basis. Professionals must explain confidentiality limits and child safeguarding or reporting obligations applicable to their work.

13. Helping children and adolescents safely

When a child may be experiencing violence, protection takes priority over adult learning activities. Do not interview repeatedly, ask leading questions, request images, or promise to keep everything secret. Listen calmly, explain what help may be needed in age-appropriate words, and contact a qualified child protection or health professional through established procedures. Children cannot be expected to manage adult safety plans independently.

In Rwanda, the Ministry of Gender and Family Promotion publishes the National Child Development Agency hotline 711. Availability and appropriate referral procedures should be verified at the time of use. [11]

14. Safe information seeking in Rwanda

Rwanda's Isange One Stop Centres provide coordinated services that may include medical assistance, psychosocial support and justice-related services. UNHCR Rwanda lists a toll-free contact number of **3029** and notes that approaching a centre may result in a GBV incident being reported to law enforcement. A person should ask about confidentiality and reporting implications when it is safe to do so. [11,12]

Service	Published contact	Important note
Isange One Stop Centres	3029	UNHCR Rwanda listing; ask about access and reporting implications
Rwanda Investigation Bureau	116 / 3512	MIGEPROF listing
Gender Monitoring Office	5798	MIGEPROF listing
MIGEPROF	9059	MIGEPROF listing
Child protection (NCDA)	711	MIGEPROF listing

These contacts were checked against published pages on 9 November 2026. Telephone access, operating arrangements and referral rules can change. This handbook does not guarantee confidential treatment, availability or a particular legal outcome. A local specialist should verify them before public release.

15. Practical learning activities

Activity 1 - Identify the form, not the person

Read each fictional example and name possible forms of harm: (a) A partner takes wages and prevents school attendance. (b) A supervisor demands sexual contact in exchange for a promotion. (c) An ex-partner repeatedly threatens to publish private images. (d) A relative restrains someone during a dispute. More than one form may apply.

Activity 2 - Separate conflict from coercive control

Compare two situations. In the first, two partners respectfully disagree over shared expenses and agree to revisit the budget. In the second, one partner keeps all money, threatens punishment for disagreement and blocks employment. Ask: What makes the second situation more concerning? Look for coercion, threats, power and loss of choice, not just the presence of disagreement.

Activity 3 - Choose supportive language

Consider which response protects dignity: "Why did you not leave earlier?" or "What support would feel safe and helpful to you?" Explain why the second is more appropriate. Do not use this exercise to pressure anyone to describe their own experience.

Activity 4 - Map safe support options

Without entering names, addresses or personal details, identify general types of support that may exist: a trusted adult, health centre, trained GBV worker, child protection worker, legal information provider or emergency service. Think about which route would be accessible, private and safe in a hypothetical situation.

Activity 5 - Responsible online response

A friend says their images are being threatened online. What should you avoid doing? Consider why forwarding the image, public confrontation, posting screenshots or using their account without permission may create more harm. Identify a safer first response, such as listening and offering information about trained support.

16. Knowledge assessment

1. Can GBV happen without physical injuries?
Yes. Sexual, psychological, economic and digital forms can occur without visible injuries.

2. Does marriage mean a person has permanently consented to sex?
No. Consent must be freely given and remains specific and revocable.

3. Is every financial disagreement economic abuse?
No. Coercive control, deprivation, threats and context distinguish abuse from ordinary disagreement.

4. Can one incident involve multiple forms?
Yes. A physical assault may also involve threats, sexual coercion or economic control.

5. Should a supporter ask for a detailed account to verify what happened?
No. Do not investigate or demand repeated disclosure. Offer respectful support and professional referral.

6. Is digital surveillance harmless when no physical contact occurs?
No. Technology can be used to intimidate, monitor or control someone.

7. What is an important time window after possible HIV exposure?
PEP assessment is time-sensitive; when indicated, it should begin as soon as possible and within 72 hours.

8. Are response services automatically confidential in every circumstance?
No. Explain that legal, safeguarding or reporting requirements may limit confidentiality.

9. Who can experience GBV?
People of any gender, while women and girls are disproportionately affected.

10. What is the first priority when someone is in immediate danger?
Consider immediate safety and appropriate urgent support; avoid actions that could escalate danger.

17. Facilitator guidance and safeguarding

A facilitator should inform learners about potentially distressing content before a session. Participation in scenarios and reflections must be optional. Never ask for personal testimonies or facilitate public identification of survivors. Provide private, verified information about support channels; explain the limits of privacy and mandatory reporting. Train facilitators to respond calmly to unexpected disclosures and to refer rather than investigate.

For publication on VUGA NDAKUMVA, every example and self-help activity should be reviewed for child safeguarding, disability access, plain-language comprehension, realistic Rwanda context and safe use on potentially monitored devices. Avoid analytics or notification designs that could inadvertently reveal a user's interest in GBV content.

18. Key messages and glossary

Key messages. GBV has many interrelated forms. Visible injury is not required for harm to be serious. Consent and personal autonomy matter. A survivor deserves non-judgmental support whether or not they report an incident. Safe professional assistance can include health, protection, psychosocial and justice services, depending on needs and wishes.

Term	Plain-language explanation
Coercion	Pressure or threats used to make someone do something against their free choice
Consent	A freely given, specific and changeable agreement
Survivor-centred	An approach prioritizing dignity, safety, informed choice and respectful support
Economic abuse	Use of financial or material control to cause harm or reduce independence
Digital abuse	Harm or coercion carried out or amplified through technology
Intimate partner violence	Abusive behavior by a current or former partner
Safeguarding	Steps to prevent and respond to harm, particularly involving children or vulnerable people

19. References and source notes

[1] World Health Organization. Violence against women. Fact sheet, 18 June 2026. https://www.who.int/en/news-room/fact-sheets/detail/violence-against-women

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[4] United Nations. What is domestic abuse? https://www.un.org/en/node/71778

[5] UN Women Australia. Technology-facilitated violence definitions in Types of violence against women and girls. 2024. https://unwomen.org.au/types-of-violence-against-women-and-girls/

[6] European Institute for Gender Equality. What is gender-based violence? https://eige.europa.eu/gender-based-violence/what-is-gender-based-violence

[7] World Health Organization. Clinical management of rape and intimate partner violence survivors. 2020. https://www.who.int/publications/i/item/9789240001411

[8] US Centers for Disease Control and Prevention. Clinical Guidance for PEP. Updated 7 October 2026. https://www.cdc.gov/hivnexus/hcp/pep/

[9] World Bank. Violence against Women and Girls: Terminology. https://www.worldbank.org/en/programs/violence-against-women-and-girls/terminology

[10] World Health Organization. Health care for women subjected to intimate partner violence or sexual violence: A clinical handbook. 2014. https://apps.who.int/iris/handle/10665/136101

[11] Rwanda Ministry of Gender and Family Promotion (MIGEPROF). Family promotion and child rights protection. https://www.migeprof.gov.rw/family-promotion-and-child-right-protection

[12] UNHCR Rwanda. Gender-Based Violence: response services. https://help.unhcr.org/rwanda/services/sgbv/

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